University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,393: Consultancy Project: Responsible Banking

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (20%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (15%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Group work group grade (40%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,393,1.00 Consultancy Project: Responsible Banking -- English -- Gava Roy

Course information

Prerequisites

Interest in banking, finance, and/or sustainability issues.

Learning objectives

During a Consultancy Project course, students:

- demonstrate ability to evaluate and classify a problem and source a solution from its onset to its conclusion;
- acquire and foster skills in the application of theoretical concepts to real-life situations;
- gain experience with actual issues in the practitioner's world that arise in the course of the consultancy project;
- foster their creativity and various skills, including teamwork, project, communication, research, writing, and presentation.

Students who participate in this course will, afterwards, be able to:

- understand the work performed by policy specialists in international organizations;
- analyze key trends and current issues in sustainable finance;
- produce evidence-based reports informing the implementation of environmental and social initiatives at a global level.

Content

This consultancy project's partner is the United Nations Environment Programme - Finance Initiative (UNEP-FI).

Students will have the opportunity to support the work of the UN Principles for Responsible Banking (PRB) Implementation Guidance Team. The PRB is a global framework to guide banks in aligning their strategy and operations with the goals of the UN Sustainable Development Goals and the Paris Climate Agreement. Around 350 banks from around the world, representing approximately 50% of global banking assets, are signatories of the PRB.

Student teams will focus their consultancy projects on one specific topic from within the following four priority themes identified by the PRB Team:

1. Business case and opportunities for sustainability
    a. Assessment of empirical evidence on how sustainability and key thematics (climate, nature, circularity, social issues) affect financial performance, value creation, and risks.
    b. Mapping of trends and financial flows in sustainability-linked financing and products across sectors, with a specific focus on banks.
    c. Identifying communication trends and positioning trends in the banking sector around sustainability.
2. Nature and biodiversity
    a. Mapping data and indicators used in nature targets and impact assessments.
    b. Mapping banks' disclosure, policies, lending, engagement, or communication practices on nature and biodiversity.
3. Circular economy
    a. Mapping financing mechanisms and best practices for circular economy businesses across regions.
    b. Comparing existing circularity taxonomies, indicators, and reporting frameworks.
    c. Mapping the social dimensions of banks' approaches to circularity.
    d. Mapping banks' approaches to plastics and their implications for circularity.
4. Sustainability-related enforcement and litigation
    a. Mapping of regulatory enforcement on sustainability issues (e.g., greenwashing, misinformation, disclosure) affecting banks.
    b. Mapping of sustainability-related litigation targeting banks.

A UNEP-FI representative will introduce the PRB during a kick-off session at the start of the semester, when students will also present their initial project ideas and receive feedback. Student teams are also encouraged to propose their own ideas related to the priority themes. Progress and preliminary results will be discussed in a mid-term meeting. Final results will be presented to the PRB team at the end of the semester

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

Students will work in small groups on a challenge presented to them by their "client". Students are responsible for a mid-term presentation which should introduce students' approach as well as highlight and discuss any roadblocks or difficulties faced. At the end of the course, students will present an in-depth analysis of the problem and a recommended solution.

This course consists mainly of independent study (in groups) and bilateral meetings between the lecturer and groups. However, there will be several in-class meetings and presentations:

- The course starts off with an introduction lecture that discusses in-depth the expectations of the course. Students are also introduced to their client and are briefed on the problem. This kick-off session also serves the formation of student groups.
- One week after the kick-off session there will be a brainstorming session with the client.
- Student groups then work independently outside and during in-class meetings on their project.
- At mid-term student groups present the chosen approach to analyze the question and their progress (as well as roadblocks and difficulties) to the academic lecturer, their client, and other student groups. Students receive feedback.
- Groups then continue to work independently and present an in-depth analysis of the problem and their recommendations to the client toward the end of the course.

Literature

The course instructor will provide recommended references, including academic journal articles and policy reports, on relevant topics during the course. Students are required to engage in additional research.

Additional information

The course instructor is Roy Gava, Affiliate Professor of Business and Public Policy at the School of Economics and Political Science (SEPS) of the University of St. Gallen. His interests include comparative public policy, financial regulation, interest groups, and text-as-data.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	20%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Midterm presentation

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	15%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	40%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Final report

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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4. Examination sub part (4/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Final presentation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

Students are expected to participate fully in all aspects of the course including group work and presentations.

- **Midterm Presentation** (20%): Student groups present their approach in addressing the question, brief on their progress, including any roadblocks or difficulties that may have been encountered. All group members will be given the same grade.
- **Final Presentation** (25%): Student groups present an in-depth analysis of the problem and their recommendations to the client. All group members will be given the same grade.
- **Final Report** (40%, max. 5'000 words): Targeted at the client, the report provides a summary of relevant research, lays down possible business options, and proposes particular courses of action. Next to an explanation of the challenge and the results of the research undertaken, it outlines the methods used and the theories applied. The report might include graphs, charts, or other visual aids that make it easier to digest the most important information. All group members will be given the same grade.
- **Active participation** (15%): Students are expected to contribute constructively to class discussions, come fully prepared to advance their project during in-class meetings, and be ready to report orally and professionally on the status of their work.

Literature

The course instructor will provide recommended references, including academic journal articles and policy reports, on relevant topics during the course. Students are required to engage in additional research.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).